The Founder Guide

The why behind every step of the Founder Quest, from a blank page to a launched business.

What this is

The Founder Guide is free, and it stays free. It is the print companion to the Founder Quest, the free build-along that walks a total beginner from a blank page to a launched business with nothing but AI and a laptop.

The Quest is the part you do. It hands you a checklist and you work through it, one step at a time, until you have a real business: a name, a legal structure, a website you own, and your first shot at customers. This guide is the part you read. It sits next to the Quest and explains the why behind every step and every checkbox, so you are never just following orders you do not understand.

None of this is a simulation. By the end you will have started an actual business, not a practice one.

Who it's for

Anyone who keeps meaning to start the thing and hasn't done it yet. You do not need money, a business background, or any experience with AI. You need a laptop, a few hours a week, and the willingness to be a beginner for a little while.

Budget is not a gate here. The program runs the same whether you have a real operating budget or close to nothing (more on that below).

If you're under 18: you can do all of this, with one adjustment. A parent or guardian stays in the loop and owns anything that legally has to belong to an adult, like the bank account, any business filing, and any account with an age minimum. You do the thinking and the work. They hold the parts the law says a grown-up has to hold, and they look things over with you before anything gets signed or paid.

How to use it

Play the Quest to do each step. Read this guide for the why behind it.

That is the whole split. The Quest is where you do the work. This guide is where the work makes sense. Every checkbox in the Quest has a reason sitting behind it, and the reason lives here, phase for phase, matched up so you can flip straight to what you need.

You do not have to read this cover to cover before you begin. Most people won't, and that is fine. The better move is to open the Quest, hit a step, and come here when you want the reasoning or you get stuck. Read the why, then go back and do the thing.

One rule runs underneath all of it. Before you paste in anything the AI wrote for you, whether it is website copy, code, or a comparison of legal options, you have to be able to explain what it says in your own words. Understanding comes before shipping, every time.

The one habit

If you take one habit from this whole program, take this one. Every phase, catch the AI being confidently wrong about something, and write it down.

Keep a running list. A note on your phone is enough. AI is fast, genuinely useful, and wrong all the time in a calm, certain voice. It will invent a fee, misstate a deadline, get a fact backwards, and deliver it in the exact same tone it uses when it is right. The tool cannot tell the difference. Your job is to.

Here is why this beats any prompt trick. Most people using AI right now have not figured this out. They read the confident answer, assume it is true, and move on. The skill almost nobody has yet is trusting the tool and checking it at the same time. You build that skill the only way anyone builds it, by getting burned on something small and low-stakes and learning to feel when an answer is a little too smooth. That is what writing it down trains. Everything else in the Quest is just a real project to practice it on.

Budget is a dial, not a gate

The same six phases work at any budget. The amount you have to spend does not change what you learn or what you end up with. It only changes how much room you have along the way.

Set your own budget before you start, and be honest about what is real for you. More to spend buys a nicer website, a small paid-ads test, paid tools that save you time. Close to nothing means free tools, a free site builder, and your own network instead of ads. Both roads end in the same place, a real business that is actually live. Plenty of businesses have started with almost no money at all.

Two things stay true at every budget:

- **Every dollar you don't spend is money you keep.** Free is a feature. Reach for the free option first, and only pay when paying clearly earns its keep.
- **The laptop is a tool you already have, not a cost of starting.** You are building with what is in front of you. That is the whole point.

If you're under 18: any money that gets spent or collected runs through the adult in the loop. Agree on a budget together before you start, so the number is clear and nobody is surprised later.

A note on the legal and money stuff

This guide walks you through the why behind picking a business structure, filing it, taxes, and fees. It will not hand you a specific number and call it the truth, because it can't. The exact fees, forms, deadlines, and taxes vary by state, and they change over time.

So the rule for anything with legal or money stakes is always the same. Look up your state's real, current numbers on its own official site (the pages that end in .gov), and confirm them there before you act. Do not trust the AI's first answer on a fee or a deadline, and do not treat this guide as the final word either.

This is educational material, not legal or tax advice. For anything that carries real stakes, a short conversation with a licensed CPA or attorney in your state is cheap insurance.

If you're under 18: the adult in the loop handles the filings and signs what has to be signed. Go through the official pages together, so you both see the same real numbers.

Phase 1: Get set up

This phase is about getting comfortable with your two main tools, your laptop and your AI, before you ask either one to build something real. It feels like the least important phase and it is quietly the most important, because everything else in the build runs on top of it. Go slow here, and the next five phases go faster.

The checklist, explained

Before you dive in, point your AI at your own situation so the week has a shape. Open your AI assistant and paste this in:

> I'm brand new to using AI to build a real business, and I'm not very technical. Ask me 5 questions about my situation, then give me the 3 things I should learn on my laptop this week. Keep it plain, no jargon.

That is also your first real conversation with the tool you'll use for everything else. Now the list.

Get your laptop set up, updated, and personalized, and install a password manager. This is your workshop for the whole build, so make it feel like yours: sign in, run every pending update, and set the basics the way you like them. The password manager is the part people skip and shouldn't, because you're about to create a pile of accounts (your AI, an email, a domain, a bank account later on), and reusing one password across all of them is the most common way small founders get hacked. Let the password manager invent and remember a different strong password for each account, so you never reuse one and never have to memorize one. Good looks like a machine that's current plus one place that holds every login, and the classic beginner mistake is a sticky note on the monitor or the same password on everything.

Install and actually open your core tools: two browsers, a notes app, your AI assistant, and a free Google account. Two browsers sounds like overkill until a site locks up or logs you out, and the second browser becomes your escape hatch and lets you stay signed into two accounts at once. The notes app is where stray ideas land before they get lost, and the free Google account gives you documents, spreadsheets, and storage at no cost. Here is the thing that trips up almost everyone: Docs, Sheets, Drive, and Gmail are not programs you download, they run right inside the browser, so you reach them by signing in, not by installing anything. Good looks like being able to open each of these without hunting for it.

If you're under 18: a parent sets up and owns these accounts with you, the AI assistant and the Google account both, and checks the age rule on whichever AI tool you choose, since some allow teens only with a parent's permission and some are built for adults only.

Start your Founder's Journal, and log your first "the AI got it wrong" entry in it. Your journal is one running document where every decision, lesson, and dead end gets written down with the date, and over the build it becomes the memory of your business. It's also home to the one habit this whole program is built around: every time you catch the AI saying something confidently wrong, you write it down right here. Don't wait for something impressive to record, because the journal is for the messy middle, not a highlight reel. Good looks like a dated entry from today that already holds your first caught mistake.

The one habit, from day one: catch the AI being wrong and write it down. Your journal is where that lives, and it starts this week.

Spend a couple of hours on keyboard shortcuts and a couple on the basics like finding files and switching windows. Moving around your laptop quickly is a skill you can learn on purpose, and the payoff compounds, because every hour you put in here saves you many hours later. You don't need all of the shortcuts, just the eight or ten you'll use every hour (copy, paste, switch apps, search your whole machine, take a screenshot), plus knowing how to find a file you saved and flip between open windows. Watch a couple of beginner tutorials made for your exact laptop and drill those few shortcuts until your fingers do them without you thinking about it. Good looks like switching windows and finding a file without slowing down, and the mistake is trying to memorize the entire list instead of the handful you actually use.

Set up one project folder: a Business folder with six numbered subfolders. Make a single folder called Business and put six subfolders inside it: 01-Research, 02-Legal, 03-Brand, 04-Website, 05-Marketing, and 06-Finances. This gives everything a home before you have anything to put in it, and the numbers keep the folders in order and line up with the phases ahead of you. The whole trick is to actually save into these folders from now on, instead of letting files pile up loose on your desktop and in your downloads. Good looks like every file you make having one obvious place to go, and the mistake is the "I'll organize it later" pile, because later never comes.

Run a "learn to prompt" session: ask the same question three ways. Take one real question about your build and ask it three times: first vaguely, then again with specifics and context, then ask the AI to critique its own answer. This is the highest-leverage skill in the entire program, and doing it on purpose lets you watch, with your own eyes, how much a specific prompt beats a lazy one. Good looks like being able to feel the difference between a throwaway prompt and a strong one, and having seen the AI find real holes in its own work. The beginner mistake is firing off one-line prompts and then blaming the tool for a weak answer, when the truth is that bad prompts are what get bad answers.

Catch the AI: during that prompt practice, keep pushing until the AI says something wrong or sloppy, then write it in your journal. That is your easy first catch, and it's the entire point of the program: the AI is fast, useful, and confidently wrong all the time, and your job from day one is to trust it and check it at the same time.

Done when: you move around the laptop without thinking, you can ask the AI a good question, your journal is started, and your first AI mistake is logged.

Here is the finished markdown section for Phase 2.

Phase 2: Find & prove your idea

This is the hardest and most important phase in the whole build, and it is the one people rush. Everything after this (the legal filing, the brand, the site, the launch) is just execution on the idea you pick here, so a weak idea turns every later phase into good work spent on the wrong thing. The goal is not simply to find an idea, it is to find one that is actually yours and then prove real people want it before you build anything.

The checklist, explained

Brainstorm at least 20 ideas (volume first, no filtering). The point of 20 is to get past the three obvious ideas everyone lands on and into the weirder, more personal ones underneath. Judging while you generate kills the good odd ideas before they can grow, so write everything down and score nothing yet. The best ideas almost never come straight from the AI, they come from combining something the AI suggests with something only you know: your interests, your skills, a problem you personally run into. Treat the AI as a brainstorming partner that pushes your thinking, not a vending machine you pull a finished idea out of, and run several prompts instead of grabbing the first thing that sounds good.

Start from yourself, so the list is built around you instead of some generic "best" business:

> Here's me: my interests are […], skills I have or could learn fast are […], my starting budget is [your budget] and I have about [X] hours a week. Don't suggest generic ideas. Find business ideas that sit where what I'm into meets what people actually pay for. For each, tell me why it fits me specifically.

Then go wide and force the count up:

> Brainstorm 20 online business ideas I could start with [your budget] and run in about [X] hours a week. For each: what it does, who the customer is, why they'd pay, realistic beginner monthly revenue, and the main risk. Don't pad. Be honest about which are oversaturated.

Then flip it and start from real problems instead of products:

> Here are 10 problems or annoyances I or people around me actually deal with: [list them]. Turn each into a possible business. Which of these would people pay to make go away?

Narrow to 5 using the scoring rubric. This is where 20 becomes 5, and the rubric keeps you honest so you pick the strongest idea and not the shiniest. Score each idea 1 to 5 on all five lines, add up the scores, and let the top five move on:

- **Personal interest.** Will you still care in six months? A boring idea you abandon in week three scores low no matter how good it looks on paper.
- **Realistic with your budget.** Can you actually start this with the money you have, not the money you wish you had?
- **Time-realistic.** Can you run it in the hours you actually have each week, around the rest of your life?
- **Solves a real problem.** Is there a real person with a real pain here, or is this a solution hunting for a problem?
- **Online-friendly.** Can you run it from a laptop, or does it quietly require a storefront, a truck, or being somewhere in person?

The common mistake is fudging the scores to keep a favorite alive, or handing "solves a real problem" a 5 because you want it to be true. Score it cold. If your favorite drops out, that is the rubric doing its job.

Do market research on each finalist. For each of your five, find out who already serves this customer, what they charge, and whether there is real room for you. Finding zero competitors is usually bad news, not good: it almost always means there is no money here, not that you found an untouched goldmine. Do this research on the real web with your own eyes, not just by asking the AI, because this is exactly the step where it makes things up.

For each finalist, map who is already there and where the gap is:

> For [idea], who are the existing players? Show me 5, what they charge, and where there's a gap a scrappy newcomer could win. Be specific, not "offer better service."

Once a favorite starts pulling ahead, try to kill it before you fall in love:

> My favorite idea so far is [idea]. Argue why it will fail. Be brutal. Give me the 5 most likely reasons it flops and what would have to be true to survive each one.

Interview at least 5 real people in your target market. This means real conversations with people who actually have the problem, not a survey and not your friends being nice. It is the single step that separates a real idea from a nice theory, and it is the one almost everyone skips because it feels uncomfortable. Do it well by asking what they do about the problem today and what it costs them, never "would you buy this?" (people are polite and will tell you yes to your face). Good looks like five conversations where you heard something that surprised you or changed the idea. If all five simply agreed with you, you asked leading questions.

If you're under 18: keep interviews to people you already know or to public and online settings, and tell a parent who you are talking to before you go do it. Never meet someone you don't know alone.

Pick ONE idea and defend it in a one to two page memo. Commit to a single idea, in writing, with the reasoning laid out. Writing is the test: if you cannot fill one page with why this idea, this customer, and this bet, you have not actually decided yet, you are just keeping three ideas alive in your head. A good memo is one a stranger could read and understand why you chose this over the others. And if the honest memo talks you out of the idea, that is a win, not a failure, you just saved yourself months.

Run it through the three validation questions. These three questions catch most doomed ideas before you spend a dollar, so answer them out loud and in writing:

- **Who specifically has this problem?** Not "everyone." Name a specific kind of person. "Everyone" is the same as no one when it comes time to actually reach them.
- **What are they doing about it now?** If the answer is "nothing," that is a flag: either the problem is not real, or you have found a genuinely underserved market. Figure out which, because the two look identical at first and lead to opposite decisions.

- **Why would they pay you?** Not "because I'm cheaper." Competing on price alone is a race to the bottom you lose to whoever has deeper pockets. You need a reason that still stands after someone else undercuts you.

If your answers come out to "everyone," "nothing," and "I'm cheaper," you do not have a validated idea yet. Go back.

Define your ideal customer in detail. Describe one specific person: who they are, where they already spend their time, and what they currently spend (in money or effort) on this problem. This matters because every phase after this one points back at this person, your brand voice, your site copy, and your launch outreach are all aimed at them. Good looks like a description specific enough that you would recognize them in a crowd. The beginner mistake is a customer so broad it is useless, like "women 18 to 65," which is not a customer, it is a census.

Catch the AI: The AI loves to invent competitors and make up "realistic monthly revenue." Pick one competitor it named and search for it yourself, or take one revenue number it stated and try to trace where it came from. When the competitor turns out to be fuzzy or the number turns out to be invented, write it down in your journal. That is your catch for this phase, and it happens to land on the exact numbers you were about to make decisions on.

Done when: you can explain your business in one sentence, name your customer, and say why they'd pay. Killing a bad idea here counts as a win, not a failure.

Phase 3: Make it legal

This is where your idea becomes a business the law recognizes. Two things happen here: you decide how the business is legally shaped, then you do the short stack of filings that let you take a real dollar from a real customer without tangling it up with your own money. It is also the phase where your AI is most likely to hand you a confident, wrong number, which makes it the best place you will get to practice catching it.

Verify it yourself. Fees and taxes vary by state and change over time, so treat any number your AI gives you (or any number you read anywhere, including here) as something to confirm on your state's official site before you act on it. For anything with real tax or liability stakes, a short call with a CPA or an attorney is cheap insurance. Nothing in this phase is legal or tax advice, it is a map of the steps.

The checklist, explained

Write the one-page memo comparing sole proprietorship, single-member LLC, and S-corp-later. This is the real work of the phase. The decision comes before the paperwork, and it is yours to research and defend, not a default you accept because the AI or some blog picked it for you. You are weighing three ways to shape the business on five things: cost, paperwork, liability, taxes, and complexity. In plain terms:

- **Sole proprietorship** is the default you land in if you just start doing business without forming anything. It is the cheapest and simplest, with the least paperwork, and the business income rides along on your personal tax return. The catch is there is no legal wall between you and the business, so a debt or a lawsuit against the business can reach your personal savings. If you operate under a name that is not your own legal name, your area may still want a "doing business as" (DBA) filing.
- **Single-member LLC** is a separate legal entity with you as the only owner. Its whole point is that wall: done right, it keeps a business debt or lawsuit from reaching your personal money (that is the "limited liability" part). It costs more to start, and most states charge something every year to keep it alive, sometimes whether or not you earned a dime. By default the IRS taxes a one-owner LLC just like a sole prop, so the LLC buys you liability protection and a more legitimate look, not a tax trick.
- **S-corp-later** is not a fourth thing you file on day one. It is a tax election you can make down the road (usually on top of an LLC) once the business earns enough that it pays for itself. It can lower a certain tax once profits are high, but it adds real overhead: running payroll, paying yourself a reasonable salary, and usually an accountant. The word that matters is "later." Almost nobody needs it in year one, so you note it as a door you can walk through, not a decision you make now.

The memo forces you to pick one and say why in your own words. Use this to get a first draft of the comparison, then check every number it gives you:

> I'm starting an online business in [your state]. My business is [description]. Compare sole proprietorship, single-member LLC, and S-corp-later on cost, paperwork, liability, taxes, and complexity. Be honest about which makes sense for a first-time founder under $50K first-year revenue. Tell me the real, state-specific fees and which ones recur every year, and remind me to verify each on my state's own site.

Good looks like a memo where the numbers came from your state's official site, not the AI's memory, and where you can defend the choice out loud. The most common beginner mistake is reaching for the LLC because it sounds "more professional" and paying to keep it alive every year when a sole prop would have done the job, or the reverse, skipping the liability wall that your specific business actually needs.

Sleep on it and read the memo back cold before filing. Filing is one of the few steps here that is a nuisance to undo, so you build in a deliberate pause. Write the memo, walk away, and read it the next day as if a stranger wrote it. You are checking whether the reasoning still holds when you are not excited, and whether any number in it is a guess you never actually verified. If it still reads right cold, file. If a line makes you wince, that is the line to go confirm.

Verify your business name across the state database, the domain, and the social handles. Before you commit to a name, make sure you can actually use it everywhere you need it. Search your state's business-entity database so you are not filing a name someone already holds, check that the matching web domain is free, and check the social handles you will want. Good looks like one name that is clear in all three places, grabbed in the same sitting so they line up. The classic mistake is falling in love with a name, filing it, and only then discovering the domain is taken or another business in your state already owns it.

File your chosen structure. This is the filing that makes the business real in your state's eyes: for a sole prop that is often a DBA or fictitious-name filing (if you need one at all), and for an LLC it is the articles of organization. Do it on your state's official site rather than through a middleman that upsells you services you do not need. What good looks like is the stamped confirmation document saved into your legal folder. A common beginner mistake is paying a slick third-party filing service for something your state lets you do directly, or forming an LLC in some other "cheaper" state you do not actually operate in.

Get an EIN from the IRS. An EIN (Employer Identification Number) is a free federal tax ID for your business, like a Social Security number for the company. You get it straight from the IRS, it costs nothing, and it usually takes about fifteen minutes online. You will need it to open a business bank account and to keep the business's taxes separate from your own. The single most common mistake here is paying one of the sites that rank at the top of search and charge a fee to "file" it for you, because the IRS gives it out for free directly and those sites are just middlemen.

Open a business bank account, and never mix business money with personal. The first rule of clean books is a wall you do not breach: business money lives in the business account, personal money lives in yours, and the two never touch. Open a dedicated business checking account (the bank will ask for your EIN and your filing documents) and run every dollar the business earns and spends through it. Good looks like a separate account opened before your first sale, not after. The mistake that haunts people at tax time is running business charges through a personal card “just for now” and then losing hours untangling it later.

Set up free bookkeeping and log your laptop as your first business asset. Bookkeeping is just the running record of money in and money out, and free tools handle it fine at this stage. Set one up now, while there is almost nothing to track, so the habit exists before the volume does. Your very first entry is the computer you are building on: it is not an operating expense, it is a business asset (capital), so it belongs on the books as one. The common mistake is “I will start tracking once there is real money,” which just means you start behind and end up guessing at your own history.

Check whether your business needs a local license. Beyond the state filing, your city or county may require a local business license or permit just to operate, and whether you need one depends entirely on where you are and what you do. Look it up on your city or county’s official site instead of assuming you are fine, or assuming you need something you do not. Good looks like a clear yes or no that you actually confirmed at the source. The beginner mistake is thinking the state filing covered everything, because the local layer is separate and easy to forget.

Catch the AI: This is the easiest phase in the whole build to catch the AI. Legal fees and tax numbers are exactly where it answers with total confidence and gets it wrong, because those numbers change by state and over time and it is working from stale memory. Pick one number it gave you, a filing fee, an annual tax, a deadline, and check it against your state’s official site. When you find the gap, log it in your journal. That is your catch for the phase.

If you’re under 18: The money and legal steps here are built for an adult, so a parent owns them. A parent or guardian is the one who opens the business bank account and whose name goes on any filing and on the EIN, because a minor generally cannot sign those into being. You still do the work: write the memo, run the name checks, fill in the forms, and walk them through your reasoning. They look the memo over with you and put their name where the law needs an adult.

Done when: you chose a structure and can defend why, the business is filed, EIN and bank account in hand, and you know what you owe and when.

I have everything I need from all four sources. The authoritative checklist is index 3 of the Quest’s PHASES array (“Brand it”), and I’ve cross-referenced the adult backbone, the teen guide (for the under-18 difference), and the syllabus for the deeper wording. Here is the finished section.

Phase 4: Brand it

Your brand is how a stranger decides, in about two seconds, whether you look like a real business or like a side hustle they scroll past. This phase is not about making things pretty, it is about making a handful of decisions once (what you sound like, what you look like, what you promise) so every future post, page, and email comes out consistent instead of improvised. The real output here is not a logo, it is a one-page brand brief that someone else could pick up and use to make on-brand content without asking you a single question.

The checklist, explained

Write a one-page brand brief. This is the actual deliverable of the whole phase, the thing everything else hangs off of. On one page, write four things: what you do in one sentence, who exactly it is for, what makes you different from everyone doing something similar, and your voice in three to five adjectives. The test for "good" is blunt: could a stranger read this page and then write a caption that sounds like you, without asking you anything? If yes, you are done, and if they would have to guess, it is still too vague. The most common beginner mistake is filling the brief with words like "quality," "affordable," and "customer-focused," which describe every business on earth and therefore describe none of them.

Run the brief with your AI as a sparring partner, not a ghostwriter:

> I'm building a brand for [business description]. My target customer is [description]. Help me develop: (1) a one-sentence positioning statement, (2) three tone-of-voice adjectives with examples, (3) five brand names with reasoning, (4) three tagline options. Push back if my positioning is generic. I want to stand out, not blend in.

Research 10 competitors and screenshot their branding. Before you design anything, go look hard at ten businesses your customer already considers, and screenshot their logos, colors, fonts, and the words they lean on. The point is not to copy them, it is to see the pattern they all share so you can deliberately break it, which is literally how you avoid looking like every other side hustle. Drop the screenshots into one place (your 03-Brand folder) so you can lay them side by side and spot the sameness. The common mistake is skipping this and designing in a vacuum, then landing on the exact same blue-and-white, rounded-font look as everyone else because that is what "professional" felt like in your head.

Pick a color palette and typography. Choose three to five colors and write them down as hex codes (the six-character codes like #1A1A1A, so they are exact and repeatable), plus one or two fonts, and free fonts are completely fine. Consistency beats cleverness here: the same three colors and same two fonts used everywhere are what make a brand feel real, more than the specific colors you land on. This is also the classic place founders lose days, so here is the rule that matters most in this phase, do not spend three days on a font, set a deadline you can actually hit and ship the decision. Good looks like a palette and fonts written down and ready to hand to someone else, and the beginner mistake is treating this like a permanent tattoo instead of a version one you can adjust after launch.

Make a logo, a transparent PNG and a square social version. Generate options with an AI image tool, refine down to one, then export the two files you will actually use everywhere: a transparent-background PNG that drops cleanly onto any color, and a square version sized for a social profile picture. Aim for simple over intricate, because your logo has to survive being shrunk to a thumbnail, and fussy detail turns to mush at that size. Give the image tool something specific to work from:

> Create a clean, modern logo for [brand name], a [business description] for [audience]. Style: [3 adjectives]. Colors: [palette]. It must work as a small social profile picture and a large website header. Show me 4 variations.

One thing worth knowing: the image the tool hands you is really a picture of a logo, and later a free tool can trace it into a sharp vector file if you ever need it large, but do not let the AI set the text for you, because it is bad at letters (more on that in Catch the AI below).

Write 3 sample headlines and 3 sample captions in your voice. Write three headlines and three social captions that sound like the voice you defined in the brief, because this is where the brief stops being theory and gets tested. If the adjectives you picked were “warm, plain, a little funny,” the captions have to actually read warm, plain, and a little funny, or the voice was just words on a page. Use your AI to draft, then rewrite every line until it sounds like a person and not a template, because AI-default copy is easy to spot and it quietly makes you look generic. These samples double as proof the brief works, since they are exactly the “on-brand content someone could make from the brief,” made by you first.

Secure your domain and matching social handles in one sitting. Buy your domain and grab the same name on your social platforms all in one sitting, on purpose, so they line up (yourname.com and @yourname everywhere). Do it together because names get taken constantly, and there is nothing worse than a great .com with the handle already gone somewhere else, forcing a mismatch your customers have to remember. Check each one live, on the real registrar and the real apps, before you commit to the name. Good looks like one consistent name across your domain and every handle, and the beginner mistake is falling in love with a name, building the whole brand around it, and only then discovering the handle is already someone else's.

If you're under 18: buying a domain needs a payment method and most social platforms set a minimum age, so a parent owns the domain registration and the accounts and sets them up together with you. You still pick the name and do the work, they just hold the keys and look things over with you.

Catch the AI: Two easy catches live in this phase. First, ask an AI image tool to put your brand name inside the logo and watch it garble the letters, misspell the word, or invent shapes that are not really letters, because image models are famously bad at text, which is the whole reason you set real type yourself. Second, ask a chat AI whether your brand name or a handle is "available," and it will often answer with total confidence even though it cannot actually check a live registry or a social platform, so it is just guessing. Verify every name and handle yourself on the real sites, catch the AI calling a taken name free, and log it in your journal.

Done when: you have a logo, palette, fonts, and a brief someone else could create on-brand content from. Don't spend three days on a font.

I have everything I need. Here is the finished Phase 5 section.

Phase 5: Build the site

This is the phase where your business stops being a folder of documents and becomes a place a stranger can visit, understand, and buy from. It is also the phase where the AI will hand you the most code and the most copy, which makes it the phase where "trust but verify" earns its keep. The goal is not just a site that works. It is a site you own and can explain every piece of, because a business you cannot explain is not really yours.

The checklist, explained

Buy your domain and connect it. Your domain (yourbusiness.com) is your address on the internet, and it is the one piece of this build you truly own and can carry to any platform later. Buying it is a separate step from building the site: you purchase the name from a registrar, then "connect" it by pointing it at your builder (the builder gives you a record or two to paste in, or does it in one click if you bought the domain through it). Good looks like typing your domain and watching your own site load with the padlock (https) showing. The most common beginner mistake is settling for the free builder address (yourbusiness.squarespace.com), which reads as amateur and cannot follow you if you ever switch, and a close second is panicking when a domain change does not appear instantly (it can take a few hours to spread, and that is normal).

If you're under 18: the registrar account, the platform subscription, and the card that pays for them go under a parent's name. They set the accounts up with you and hold the logins.

Choose your platform with the decision tree, then set it up. Pick your builder based on what you are selling, not on which one has the slickest ads, because each platform is built around one kind of transaction and fighting that choice later is misery. Run the decision tree:

- **Physical products you ship?** Go to Shopify. It handles inventory, cart, shipping, and sales tax so you are not duct-taping those on later.
- **Digital products or courses?** Go to Squarespace or Webflow.
- **A service with bookings?** Go to Squarespace plus a scheduler (a booking tool that lets people grab a time and, if you want, pay).
- **A portfolio or a simple one-pager?** Go to Carrd (the cheapest option) or Squarespace.

Good looks like being able to say in one sentence why you are on your platform ("I ship a physical product, so Shopify runs the cart, shipping, and tax for me"). The most common beginner mistake is picking the trendy platform a video told them to use, then bolting on five plugins to force it to do a job it was never built for. (Prices change over time, so check each platform's current pricing on its own site before you commit.)

Build the five pages, and give each one a job. The minimum real site is five things: a Home page that says what you do at a glance, an About page that tells the true story of why you started (people buy from people, so this is where trust gets built), a Product or Service page with the offer, the price, and the button that takes the money, a Contact page so a human can reach you, and a Footer carrying your legal links. Give each page one job and one obvious next step instead of a wall of everything. Those footer links (a privacy policy and terms) are not decoration: payment processors usually require them, and what you are legally required to post varies by where you and your customers live, so look up your own situation (this is not legal advice). Good looks like a visitor never wondering "what now," and the common beginner mistake is a ten-page menu nobody needs, or an About page of "passionate team committed to excellence" fluff instead of your real reason for starting.

Make it mobile-first. Most people who visit your site will see it on a phone, so the phone version is the real version and the laptop version is the bonus. Design and check on the small screen first: text readable without pinch-zooming, buttons big enough for a thumb, images not cut off, and nothing spilling off the side. Good looks like doing the entire buy-or-contact flow one-handed on a phone without frustration. The most common beginner mistake is designing on a big laptop screen and never once opening the site on a phone, which is exactly where the hero text ends up gigantic and the buy button ends up half off the screen.

Write every word yourself, and let the AI edit. You are the author, and the AI is your editor, not your ghostwriter. This matters because AI-default copy is instantly recognizable and it quietly kills trust, and because you cannot sell in a voice that is not yours. Draft it rough in your own words first, then use the AI to tighten and cut, then rewrite its suggestions back into how you actually talk, with no "Lorem Ipsum," no "[tagline here]," and no "Coming soon" on a page you are launching. Use this to get an editor's pass, not a first draft:

> I'm writing copy for my business website. Business: [description]. Customer: [description]. Brand voice: [3 adjectives]. Write: (1) a hero headline (10 words max) and subheading (20 max), (2) a 3-paragraph About explaining why I started this, (3) a value proposition for the product page, (4) CTA button text that isn't generic. Read like a real person, not AI. No marketing speak.

Good looks like copy that sounds like you talking to one specific customer, and the most common beginner mistake is pasting the AI's first draft straight onto the page, where it reads generic because every competitor's AI wrote the same three sentences.

Set up a real email address on your domain. A message from you@yourbusiness.com tells a customer you are a real operation, and a message from yourbusiness2025@gmail.com tells them it is a weekend hobby, and some people will not send money to a hobby. Most registrars and platforms sell email hosting, or you can route it through a mail provider, and you can forward it into the inbox you already check so you are not living in two places. Good looks like sending and receiving from the domain address and having it land normally. The most common beginner mistake is either launching on a personal free email or buying the email hosting and never finishing the forwarding, so the first customer message silently bounces.

Give visitors a way to pay or leave a lead. Every visit should let a person do the one thing that matters: buy now, or hand you their contact info so you can follow up. A site with no path to a sale or a lead is a brochure, not a business, and this phase is where you prove the site can actually take a dollar or a name. If you sell, connect a payment processor and run one real test purchase on yourself, then refund it. If you are pre-product or high-touch, put a lead form, an email signup, or a booking link somewhere impossible to miss. Good looks like a checkout or a lead form you have personally tested end to end, and the common beginner mistake is the buy button that goes nowhere or the contact form that never delivers the message, both of which you only catch by testing them yourself.

If you're under 18: a payment processor or merchant account is legally set up by an adult, so a parent owns it, the money lands in their account, and they can see every transaction. Set it up together and agree up front how your share gets to you.

Test on a phone, a tablet, and a laptop. Open the live site on real devices, not just the builder's preview, because the preview lies and real hardware is what catches the broken button, the tiny text, the image that will not load, and the form that will not submit. Tap every link, run the full buy-or-contact flow on each device, then hand your phone to someone who has never seen the site and watch where they get stuck. Good looks like a stranger figuring out what you do in five seconds and how to buy or reach you in thirty, on a device that is not the one you built it on. The most common beginner mistake is only ever viewing the site on the single screen you designed it on, so every visitor on a different device meets a bug you never saw.

"Explain this" comes before "make it work"

This is the rule that governs the whole phase. Before you paste in any AI-built code, any script, or any block of copy, you have to be able to say in plain words what it does and why it is there. If you cannot explain it, you do not ship it, because the moment it breaks (and something always breaks) you will be helpless inside your own business. Make the AI walk you through anything it hands you, line by line, until you actually understand it. Owning your site means being able to explain every piece of it, not just watching it work.

Catch the AI: When the AI hands you code, make it explain each line before you paste it, then find one line that does not do what it claimed, and log it. This is one of the easiest catches in the whole run, because AI-written code is full of small confident lies: a setting flipped the wrong way, a label that does not match what the code actually does, a cheerful "this handles mobile" that handles nothing. One caught line, written in your journal, and you walk away with both a safer site and your Phase 5 catch.

Done when: a stranger finds your site, gets what you do in 5 seconds, knows how to buy or contact you in 30, and you can explain every piece of it.

I have everything I need. The Quest's Phase 6 (index 5) checklist, its single launch-plan prompt, the note, the catch-the-AI beat, the done-when line, plus the deeper teaching from both guides and the syllabus. Here is the finished section.

Phase 6: Launch it

Launch is where the project stops being a project and becomes a business, because a stranger can finally hand you money. It is also the phase most people quietly skip, because launching means real people can say no. That is exactly the point. A real no teaches you more than an imagined yes ever will.

The checklist, explained

Before you tick a single box, get the map. Give your AI the shape of your launch and make it build a concrete 30-day plan, then hold it to the honesty rule in that last line.

> My business is launching: [description]. Customer: [description]. Budget for launch marketing: [remaining]. Build me a 30-day launch plan that (1) doesn't rely only on paid ads, (2) uses my network and social, (3) has specific daily actions, not vague ones like "post on social," (4) has measurable goals, (5) honestly assesses whether it can hit them. Push back if my targets are unrealistic.

Social accounts on at least two platforms. Pick the two platforms where your customer already spends time, not the two you personally enjoy. Two is the number because one leaves you at the mercy of a single algorithm, and five means you go quiet on all of them. Match the platform to the buyer (a visual product wants a visual platform, a local service wants wherever your town gathers), and use the same handle you locked in your brand phase so everything lines up. The common beginner mistake is choosing platforms by where you like to scroll instead of where the people who would actually pay you already are.

If you're under 18: a parent owns and supervises these accounts with you, platforms set their own minimum ages, and a parent stays in the loop on who you post to and message.

First 10 pieces of content posted. Post ten real things before you ask anyone to buy, so your profile is not a ghost town when the first curious person clicks. An empty account with a single "buy now" post reads like a scam, and content is what earns you the right to sell. Mix it up, what you do, the thing itself, the behind-the-scenes of building it, and the problem you take away, all in the brand voice you wrote earlier and edited so it does not sound like the AI. The mistake almost everyone makes is turning all ten posts into a sales pitch, or polishing them forever and never actually hitting post.

Soft-launch to the very people you interviewed in Phase 2, first. Before a single ad or cold message, go back to the exact people who sat down and talked to you about the problem, and tell them the thing is live. They already told you the problem was real, which makes them the warmest audience you will ever have and your most likely first yes. Send a personal message, not a broadcast, something like “you told me [the problem], I went and built [the thing], here it is.” The mistake is jumping straight to strangers and ads because messaging people who know you somehow feels scarier than hiding behind a paid campaign.

Direct outreach to at least 20 potential customers. Reach out to twenty real potential customers one at a time, by DM, email, or in person. At launch your traffic is thin, and direct human outreach is how the first sales actually happen, and it hands you the real objections you cannot get any other way. Personalize every one, lead with their problem instead of your product, and make one specific ask. The mistake is pasting the identical pitch to twenty people, which reads as spam, or counting one public post as “outreach” to twenty.

Lead capture live. Put up a working way to catch the people who are interested but not ready to buy today, an email signup, a contact form, or a DM funnel. Most people do not buy on the first visit, and if you cannot capture them, that interest is gone the second they close the tab. Test it yourself end to end, fill in the form from your phone and confirm the lead actually lands somewhere you will see it. The classic mistake is a form that looks fine but quietly goes nowhere because nobody ever submitted a real test, or having no capture at all so every non-buyer vanishes for good.

If your budget allows, one small paid-traffic test, read honestly. This one is optional and only if your budget has room, and the point is the reading, not the spending. Set a small fixed amount you decide up front, send that traffic to one page, and then work out the three numbers that matter, what a click cost you, what a lead cost you, and what a sale cost you. Good looks like being able to say “a click cost me this, a lead cost me that, a sale cost me this much,” and knowing what those numbers tell you about whether the funnel actually works. The beginner mistake is judging the test on likes and impressions instead of those three costs, or throwing more money in to chase a number before you have even read the result of the first.

If you’re under 18: paid ads need an ad account and a payment method, so a parent owns that account and sets the spending limit with you.

First sale, or an honest write-up of why none happened. You finish this step one of two ways, a real paying customer, or a specific documented autopsy of why not, and a launch with no sale still counts if you wrote down exactly why. If you sold, note how it came, which channel and what the buyer said. If you did not, get specific about where it broke, because no traffic at all, traffic but no clicks, and clicks but no buyers each point at a completely different fix. The mistake is quietly calling the launch "done" with neither a sale nor a write-up, because that is the one outcome that teaches you nothing.

Verify before you take money: whether you owe sales tax on that first sale varies by state and changes over time, so confirm it on your state's official site rather than on the AI's say-so. This is not tax advice.

If you're under 18: taking card payments runs through a payment processor that a parent owns and sets up with you, and the business money still stays separate from personal.

A launch retrospective: what worked, what didn't, what's next. Write an honest review of the whole launch while it is still fresh. This is where a blurry two weeks turns into knowledge you can reuse, and it is the exact same retro you will run on every launch you ever do after this one. Keep it to three honest buckets, what worked, what did not, and what is next, backed with specifics and your real numbers instead of feelings. The mistake is skipping it because you are tired, or writing vague vibes like "went okay" instead of something a stranger could read and know what to change.

Catch the AI: When your AI builds that 30-day plan, it will hand you goals that sound great and are not real, something like 500 followers, 50 leads, and 10 sales in the first month. Pick one target and make it defend the math, where exactly do those 500 followers come from, day by day, starting from zero? Watch it walk the number back, and log it. This is the last catch of the run, and by now you should see it coming a mile away.

Done when: you launched. You got customers, or you learned exactly why you didn't. Either is a win. Failure with learning beats fake success.

I've absorbed the voice and framing. Here is the finished closing markdown.

What comes next: getting more customers

You launched. For this guide, that's the finish line. It's also a door.

Behind it is the next real skill: getting customers on purpose instead of by luck. Launching proved that people will buy. Growth is reaching more of them, and reaching them for less than they're worth to you.

The honest way to do that is small paid tests you actually read, and there's a companion to this guide for exactly that: the Meta Ads playbook. It walks you through running a tiny ad budget and reading the real numbers (what a click costs, what a lead costs, what a sale costs) so you can tell when to spend more and when to stop. It teaches you to trust your own dashboard over anyone's promise. A guru with a magic number is selling you something. The numbers on your own account are the only ones that are true.

No rush. Get the launch real first. But when you're ready to grow, it's the same move you've practiced this whole time: run a small test, read what actually happened, and don't believe anyone (the AI included) until the numbers back it up.

If you're under 18: a paid ad account runs on a real payment method in an adult's name, so a parent owns the account and sits with you to set the budget and read the results. You still do the thinking. They hold the card.

Final word

The person who comes out of this having actually built a real business, filed real paperwork, and used real AI tools operates at a different level than the version of you that kept meaning to start. Not because of the money. Because you stopped being someone who talks about it and became someone who did it.

You won't be impressed by AI anymore. You'll know how to use it, and you'll know when it's wrong. You won't be nervous about starting things. You'll have started a real one and taken it all the way to launch. You won't be intimidated by business. You'll have had your hands on the moving parts, and none of them are magic.

That's the win: the skill, and the habit that runs underneath it, trusting the tool and checking it at the same time. That habit works on an AI answer, on a filing fee you looked up on your state's official site instead of taking a stranger's word for it, on an ad number someone swore by. Carry it into whatever you build next, and you'll build it as someone who finishes.

The revenue, whatever it comes to, is the bonus.

You built a real thing. Now go build the next one.

Free from the AI Actually Foundation. Use it, change it, pass it on.